

Topic A1: Alfred the Great and the Vikings, 793-c900

The focus of this topic is on the seminal 9th century, which saw a devastating series of Viking attacks which nearly ended in the conquest of the whole of England but for the actions of Alfred of Wessex, the only English monarch to be known as 'the Great'. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of this topic offer a framework for understanding the themes of order and challenge to order. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them, for example the importance of divisions amongst the ruling Saxon elite and betrayal in explaining Viking success (bullet points 2 and 3).

The first bullet point relates to the nature and structure of Anglo-Saxon England four centuries after the departure of the Romans. Students should be aware of the political divisions which had emerged from the piecemeal Anglo-Saxon settlement and the evolution of the primacy of Northumbria, Mercia and Wessex from the original heptarchy. They should be aware of the dominant Christian culture and the evolution of a prosperous agricultural and commercial society enjoying links with Carolingian Europe and Rome. Detailed questions will not be set on political developments prior to the capture of York in 866.

The second bullet point relates to the challenge posed first by raids and piracy from the men of Scandinavia (itself testament to the prosperity of the new Anglo-Saxon culture) and then the enhanced challenge of the 860s and 870s when the 'great army' turned from plundering Carolingian Europe to the settlement and conquest of targets in the island of Britain. Students should be aware of the reasons for the success of the 'Great Army' in capturing York, partly explained by divisions in the Northumbrian royal house, and subjugating Northumbria and later East Anglia and Mercia.

The third bullet point relates to the assault on Wessex and the crisis years of the early part of Alfred's reign. Students should understand the extent of the threat and the reasons for the Vikings' limited but still dangerous success in the years to 878. They should appreciate the importance of Saxon 'quislings' such as Ealdorman Wulfhere and the reasons why Alfred was able to survive and win a decisive victory at Edington.

The fourth bullet point relates to the most constructive period of Alfred's reign when the renewed vulnerability of the Carolingian Empire gave England a breathing space and Alfred the chance to strengthen his kingdom through the building of Burhs and the re-organisation of the defences of his realm. Students should be aware of his achievements in extending his effective control to London, Kent and parts of Mercia; his re-organisation of military resources and the power to resist further attack; and his promotion of a cultural and religious renaissance.

**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic: A2, The
Norman Conquest
and its Impact on
England, 1066-
1135**

The focus of this topic is on the conquest of Saxon England and its impact in the reigns of the Conqueror and his two sons. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of this topic offer a framework for understanding the themes of royal power and control and challenges to that power and control. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example a question on the impact of the conquest on the Church or royal power would draw on both bullet points 1 and 4.

The first bullet point relates to the nature of late-Saxon England on the eve of the conquest. Students should be aware its relative wealth and urbanisation (10 per cent) with successful commercial centres in places like London and York and the existence of fine coinage hinting at an administrative sophistication, possibly unique in western Europe. The proliferation of churches supports the same impression of a wealthy and increasingly ordered society recovering from the ravages of an earlier period. Students should be aware of the nature of monarchy under Edward the Confessor and the important position of regional Earls wielding great power locally. They should be aware of Harold Godwinson's power and position, how he gained the throne in 1066 and the challenge he encountered from his brother Tostig and Harald Hardrada in the autumn of that year.

The second bullet point relates to the Norman challenger and students should have some understanding of William's position as Duke of Normandy and the nature of his duchy, in particular the fighting prowess and techniques developed there. Students should understand the nature of his claim and the assistance given by the Church in the light of the Papacy's quarrel with Stigand. They should understand the conduct of the campaign in 1066 and why William was ultimately successful.

The third bullet point relates to William's securing of his realm and the extended resistance and fighting between 1068 and 1071. In particular in western Mercia and Northumbria, the latter leading to the devastation of much of the north and the transformation of Viking York into a Norman city. Students should be aware of the extensive castle building and the great survey of the conquered realm in 1086.

The fourth bullet point relates to the broad social, political and economic consequences of the conquest and students should understand in what ways Anglo-Saxon England had been transformed. They should be aware of the extent to which a new landowning elite had emerged and the changed relationship between monarch and land-owner in the conquered kingdom. 'New customs' refers to such developments as the creation of extensive royal forests and new courts and forest laws to protect royal rights. Students should also be aware of the effects on the Church and the impact of ecclesiastical reforms under the archbishops of Canterbury, Lanfranc and Anselm. It is not intended that students should have a detailed knowledge of the political events of the reigns of William, Rufus and Henry.